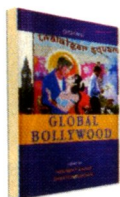


Crossing Borders

Bollywood can never be truly global until it conquers the land of Hollywood

[By Kaveree Bamzai]



GLOBAL BOLLYWOOD

Edited by ANANDAM P. KAVOORI AND ASWIN PUNATHAMBEKAR
Oxford

Price: Rs 695
Pages: 314

A book on Global Bollywood comes out just before *Slumdog Millionaire* changes the game?

Aww. Talk about bad timing. You could argue that the multiple Oscar-winner is not an Indian film, though Anil Kapoor doing the bhangra in Kodak Theatre and A.R. Rahman repeating the *Deewar* dialogues looked suspiciously like an all-out-Indian party. But clearly it

could be a turning point for Indian cinema, taking it out of the Jackson Heights' ghettos and moving it into *Vanity Fair*'s must-attend post-Oscar party and *The Tonight Show* with Jay Leno.

It's not happened overnight. And that is where this book, edited by Anandam P. Kavoori and Aswin Punathambekar, steps in. Here's Amitabh Bachchan, quoted in a piece by Ashish Rajadhyaksha, *The Bollywoodisation of Indian Cinema*: "Once, I was walking down London's Piccadilly Circus and I saw this group of Kurds running towards me. I thought they wanted to assassinate me. But they stopped right there and started singing songs from *Amar Akbar Anthony* and *Muqaddar Ka Sikandar*." Bachchan is modest, which is why he can sound surprised but now being accosted by foreign fans has become routine for Indian actors.

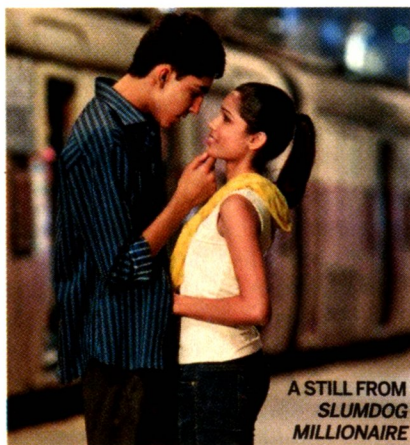
At the heart of this increasing globalisation is not just the power of our stories—though it seems westerners or Indians who have spent a long time in the West seem best prepared to show it on the world stage. It is also the power of India's economy, still somewhat stable, in a sea of uncertainty. The big bucks are prompting Steven Spielberg to make films with Reliance money just

as it is persuading Kylie Minogue to literally dance to Farah Khan's choreography. Shekhar Kapur's prophecy of Spiderman revealing his Asian face may not have come true but yes, Rajnikant's *Muthu* was an enormous hit in Japan and as Daya Kishan Thussu writes in *The Globalisation of "Bollywood"*, India's syncretic culture makes it well placed to "deal with diversity in a globalised world".

At the same time, as Kalyani Chadha and Kavoori point out in *Exoticised, Marginalised, Demonised: The Muslim "Other" in Indian Cinema*, even as Indian cinema flexes its transnational muscle, it will have to be careful of how it depicts the other. As Indian films acquire official Pakistani screenings after decades of piracy, they

will also have to become more sensitive to the portrayal of Muslims. It's something Hollywood faces every day post 9/11, as it walks a fine line in movies such as *Syriana* and *Body of Lies*.

As in all compendiums, there are some articles that seem to have been included only because they were written, especially the one on same-sex movies and the film magazine, *Stardust*. The articles on the Internet age in Bollywood by Ananda Mitra (sadly missing out on



A STILL FROM SLUMDOG MILLIONAIRE

the biggest blog of all by the Big B) and the on-line fans groups (which fortunately does mention A.R. Rahman) are more enlightening. But there's a disquieting sense of incompleteness once you're done with the book. What's the future for Indian cinema in a world where Danny Boyle can make a movie with Anil Kapoor and Mira Nair can plan a film with Hilary Swank? What happens to Hollywood with over half its box-office revenues coming from out of the US and what happens to India with its big films making more than Rs 25 crore on an average thanks to the diaspora? Perhaps you can't expect the answer in a book that has a poster with Trafalgar Square on it. Wrong country. Bollywood can never be truly global until it conquers America. ■



A TIME OF TRANSITION: RAJIV GANDHI TO THE 21ST CENTURY

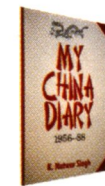
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